with a piece of calico hanging carefully round her shoulders. Her ears, neck and arms were adorned with precious stones, gold rings and bracelets, and her head covered in a piece of calico.' Both the queen and her guards belonged to a people Nieuhof called Nayros or Nairos – today usually written Nairs – which Nieuhof's English translator misinterpreted as 'negroes', giving rise to a number of highly misleading prints.

Pliny the Elder in his *Natural History* refers to 'Nerae' living in the 'Capitalis' mountains, which may well be a reference to the Nairs. Copper-plate land grants from the ninth century onwards mention local chieftains thought to be Nairs acting as witnesses to agreements between local rulers and Christian and Jewish traders. But they remain shadowy figures until the arrival of the Portuguese, by which time the Nairs had gained a fearsome reputation as warriors.

Having encountered the Nairs on the battlefield, Johannes Nieuhof was well aware of their fighting abilities. 'The Nayros are brought up to the war,' he wrote.

> They apply themselves from their infancy to the use of arms, and frequently fight together with swords and targets [round shields], which renders them infinitely active in that sport. They are the best wrestlers in the world, and are very nimble on foot. They attack their enemies quite naked, their privites only being covered … The Nayros women are clothed in the same manner as the men, so that there is not the least distinction to be seen between boys and girls, till the breasts begin to appear in the last … They bore holes through the ears of both boys and girls, which they fill up with palm-tree leaves rolled together. These rolls they make bigger and bigger by degrees till the holes are extended to the utmost and … they adorn them with gold, silver and jewels. Though the Nayros are very bold and brave,